to Kabul, relying on our promises of protection,' he wrote in his journal that evening.

> They had, many of them, reopened their shops. These people have now been reduced to utter ruin. Their goods have been plundered, and their houses burnt over their heads. The Hindoos in particular, whose numbers amount to some 500 families, have lost everything they possess, and they will have to beg their way to India in the rear of our columns. The Chindawol has had a narrow escape. I doubt if our parties of plunderers would not have forced an entrance had not the Gholam Khana [the elite Qizilbash household guard] stood to their arms, and showed and expressed determination to defend their property to the last.[98]

Nott was equally disillusioned. 'What we are staying here for I am utterly at a loss to know,' he wrote on 9 October, 'unless it be to be laughed at by the Afghans, and the whole world.'[99]

On the 10th, the British woke to find the first snows of winter dusting the hills around Kabul. Keen to avoid being caught in the sort of blizzards that had helped obliterate Elphinstone's army, and having now burned down almost all of the town, Pollock issued an order that morning that the British were to withdraw two days later.

That the British were about to march out of Afghanistan had been kept a strict secret, and much of the Kabul nobility had come over to the British camp assuming that the occupation was to continue as before. Mohan Lal, who in many cases had been the go-between, was especially appalled by what he saw as an outright betrayal. 'I could hardly show my face to them at the time of our departure,' he wrote later. 'They all came full of tears, saying that "we deceived and punished our friends, causing them to stand against their own countrymen, then leaving them in the mouth of lions".' Mohan Lal realised, as everyone else did too, that Akbar would almost certainly return to Kabul as soon as the British had left and would 'torture, imprison, extort money from and disgrace all those who had taken our side'.[100] Shah Fatteh Jang knew this to be the case too; within a day of Pollock's announcement he had abdicated the throne and announced he would be returning to India with his blind uncle, Shah Zaman. His younger brother Shahpur, Shuja's favourite son, volunteered to stay on in his place, but few believed his rule would last more than a few weeks.

In an effort to give Shahpur's rule a chance of survival, on 11 October Pollock dragooned what was left of the Kabul nobility up to the Bala Hisar